Vladimir Herdman
Dr. Pitts
The Hero's Journey
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Critical Response 1: The Return

After every year of college, after every day of class in high school, after every sporting event, and day trip, and camp, and time, and escape: I have returned home. Time and again, I have found myself out in the world changing at an imperceptible level, changing how I act and live through my experiences, only to seek the safety and refuge of my familiar life, of the status quo back home. Somewhere along the line, however, I've discovered a new feeling sprouting when I return home, something outside the feelings of familiarity and safety only somewhere you've grown up can bring. I feel awkward. I feel this place I expected has also changed, or that my perception of it has forced a difference to appear. The issue in the Hero's Journey is that it assumes where we return to is still the same as when we left it.

Change is relative to some point. For the Hero's Journey, the final return to familiarity is an important aspect in actually seeing how the hero has changed because it gives us a frame of reference. Going back to where the journey started reminds us of how the hero was "initially," and also lets us see the hero "act different" in the same world they were once in. Showing where one began and where they end up, all the small changes along the way hit the hero all at once, everything culminating into the return exposing the overall change made to the hero. For the reader, this is the moment to show how all the story has had an impact on the hero. For the hero, this is the moment that all the struggle, and fighting, and victory or loss becomes wisdom, something they have brought back to home.

The problem here is that this is a narrative concept created for the story of the Hero's Journey, a technique of highlighting change through differences. Heraclitus of Ancient Greek once said: "We both step and do not step into the same river, we both are and are not." paraphrasing the older structure of writing, Heraclitus is talking about the "flux" of change across the world, and uses a metaphor here to express that no one steps into the same river twice, because that is not the same person, and that is not the same river; while we change in life, the world around us also changes. The Hero's Journey, in order to highlight the changes of the hero through their journey, makes the assumption that one *can* return home, and that the home they return to is still the same as when they started their journey.

I had left home before, but entering into the summer before my first year of college, I was preparing for my longest leave yet. Inside of me were feelings of excitement, of expectation for opportunity, of want to leave behind the world I knew and explore something new after 18 years near the same place, but also trepidation; it is a feeling like no other, fear at a change to come, but at the same time hope for something interesting, for an exploration of the self. Even in small parts of our lives, the Hero's Journey shows itself, if not fully through each stage, maybe as the sense of going and coming from experience to experience.

However I changed that first semester, I still felt like myself after it all. I did, however, notice something on my drive back to Northeast Ohio: I felt weird. Maybe I'm too young to wax on feelings I still don't understand, but that's the best I can describe it: I felt weird. Driving all the way home, pulling up to the driveway, reaching for the key that's been on my keychain this whole time, and just walking in like it's another day. What hit first was how everything still *looked* the same: the layout of my room, the decorations on the walls, and photos, photos of me and *who I was* before I left. The weirdness in me stayed the whole trip back. And that's what it became for me, a *trip* back home, not a return; because as I changed physically and mentally, the changes back home were more internal: dust floated a bit more through the air, I couldn't just sleep like when I was living there, and I knew I had to go out again.

Home was different. I and this house were different. I wasn't back to stay, I had to leave again. I had to continue a journey.

The appeal of returning to familiarity, to a safety we once knew, is a strong one, and the Hero's Journey uses this idea to highlight the changes that occur over the course of a story. While a nice sentiment, no one ever really returns to the same place twice, if at all. The Hero's Journey fails to take into account that no one ever *truly* returns. The journey home is just another step through the looping of our experiences, of the continuation of one longer journey over the course of a life. As the journey continues, so to do the changes and our returns. No river the same.

But I wonder: Are we at all familiar to ourselves? Is "home" in this sense less a place than a past self? Are we always in flux?